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Mike Davis

Mike Davis has fashioned a robust career as a trombonist, composer, arranger, and music educator. His history of gigs and accomplishments include tours with the Rolling Stones, sessions with Bob Dylan, and concerts with his own Hip-Bone Big Band.

Mike was interviewed via Zoom on April 1, 2024 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe, I'm very pleased to have Mike Davis with me for the Fillius Jazz Archive. Welcome, sir.

MD: Good to be with you, Monk. Thanks so much for having me.

MR: Right off the top of the bat, would you define "freelance" as in freelance musician?

MD: That's a great question. I mean I think of a freelance player as somebody who basically has the ability and the range stylistically and do a lot of, a wide variety of work. And I think if that's not the definition that would certainly be a helpful quality if you're going to be a freelance player. And I guess to a certain degree freelance implies that you're not holding down a steady, full time job I suppose. But a freelance player to me is everybody outside of say somebody who has an orchestral job or somebody who has a professorship at a university or college, and people who just aren't relying on one single thing to make a living as a musician.

MR: That sort of defines what your career has been. Would you agree with that?

MD: I totally agree with that. Absolutely.

MR: Yeah. What have you done over the years to make sure that you never miss a gig?

MD: Well it's — I'll tell ya, first of all I'm a nervous, paranoid wreck. I'm originally from California but I've been in New York so long that I'm, you know, the classic paranoid New Yorker. So I'm always, I'm habitually early — like really early. So you know I always say I'd rather be two hours early to a gig than be five minutes late. So there's that part of it, and then I actually keep an old-fashioned date book that I write in by hand and that's the only thing I really feel comfortable doing. I get made fun of by my sons and rightfully so, I should kind of jump into the — maybe even jump into the twentieth century, then we can go to the twenty-first century. But yeah I try to be pretty meticulous about it and I've never — I haven't been late or missed a gig so far but I'll knock on wood because sure enough tomorrow you know, something bad happens on the George Washington Bridge and I don't get in.

MR: I'm going to pause for one second to turn off a fan. Yes I have a refrigerator calendar and

think three times in my career I've done that, missed something, and boy that is a bad feeling.

MD: Oh it's terri- yeah. It's not where you want to be, that's for sure.

MR: I'm wondering, about the time you were at Eastman and looking at it as a career, did you have this urge to do multiple things in the music business? Or was it a practical decision that came as it went along? Like opportunities came up and you said well I bet I can do this? How calculated was it?

MD: Yeah that's another great question, Monk. I think it was pretty calculated. I had a jazz background as a kid, my dad was a jazz educator at a community college out in California. So I was around it a lot and I played piano and I played drums before I got to the trombone. And you know I always just kind of wanted to be able to make a living as an instrumentalist even though my passion was certainly jazz. But you know my degree from Eastman was in classical trombone but that was back in the day when they didn't have an undergraduate jazz major. But I got a lot out of that. That was a tremendously helpful degree. And you know to be quite honest, Monk, my main goal was to become a studio musician and so people like Bill Reichenbach and Chuck Findley and Urbie Green and, you know, scores of others but those come to mind right away. You know I looked at all of them and they were a generation or sometimes two generations ahead of me, and I just noticed how versatile they were and how they could be put into any situation and be able to function at a high level. So I really kind of wanted to do that and then obviously play jazz as well. And because I had the classical background from Eastman, you know I started getting calls to do movie sessions and things of that nature, which are more — lend themselves more generally speaking to a classical approach but with pop sensibility to your approach. But anyway I kind of always was looking at doing a variety of things and I really liked that and I think trying to model myself after those studio musicians, it was kind of incumbent on me to be able to do different — stylistically do different things. So it kind of was — in a way it was calculated but in a way it was natural because that's kind of what I was trying to do.

MR: You're expected to play the part basically correct the first time. Is that true?

MD: I would say it's partially true. I mean I think it's different for different types of things. Like for instance if you're playing in a large orchestra for a film score, the chances of them taking the first take are very low because there's microphone issues, there's maybe some copying issues in the parts, there's balance issues that they want to go back and check. So you will have an opportunity to get a take or two, and I think, you know certainly in big band recording stuff, all kinds of other, TV commercials which used to be a big thing in New York, typically they don't take the first take, but you want to certainly

type of jazz recording for sure, then you want to be on your game as much as you can be on that first take because that might have a vibe that really lends itself to, you know, the music being served as best as possible and you might get something that you don't get in subsequent takes. I know in producing my own records, and we just did a new big band record last year. And you know I'm not sure we kept — of the ten tracks there might have been one that was a first take but most of them were second or third takes. But then after that I find it gets to diminishing returns and then you're kind of like oh wow this wasn't as good and then now it's a little bit dangerous when you're producing it like when do you call it and say okay we can work with this and let's stay with this one. But that's what these really good producers have figured out — how to you know, not go over the cliff and start getting diminishing returns.

MR: This morning I was watching your video of "Open City."

MD: Yeah, yeah.

MR: It just sounded fantastic. The recording quality and the playing, the whole package. Do you recall how many takes that one took?

MD: I do actually. Thank you for mentioning that track. I'm super fond of it and it was actually a composition/arrangement by my son, Cole Davis, who is an outstanding bass player and writer as well. And that was three takes. We did three takes on that. And all three of them were usable. In fact sometimes we'll use a little bit — oh you know what? I like this solo from that take so let's like move — you know you can, the technology is at such a high level nowadays, there's a lot of — you know editing is the best word for it. There's a lot of editing you can do with a good engineer. But for instance the two soloists on that were Troy Roberts on tenor saxophone and Mike Rodriguez who is one of my favorite trumpet players on trumpet. And all three of their solos it was just like what do you want? Do you want a ten or a ten or a ten? Which one would you like? So those guys make it so easy and everybody played so great. And I have to mention that our drummer, Jared Schonig really just played so beautifully on the whole record but on that track in particular. Overall we went with Take #3 on that.

MR: Yeah your drummer had a — he has a great expression on his face when he gets through it.

MD: He is so fun to watch and he's like I can't watch him when my band's playing 'cause I'm sitting next to him. And so he's really passionate about his playing and puts — I mean you know strangely enough Monk, he was really really sick at those recording sessions. He had gotten a stomach bug and it was questionable whether he was able to do it. And we brought in a bunch of hydration drinks and stuff for him and he would just lay down in between takes and — but you'd have no idea by the way he played. So much energy

MR: I want to try a little experiment that I don't think I've ever done this in an interview, but one thing I liked about that track and some others I listened to of yours is that they have something that's memorable when it's over. And you can sing it back in your head. So if someone asked you "Oh yeah, what's that thing 'Open City' you did, how does that go again?" How would you verbalize something from the tune?

MD: Yeah.

MR: What would you verbalize?

MD: I'm not a good singer so I won't sing.

MR: Well go ahead 'cause I'm not either.

MD: I mean I could, in a really horrific way sing the melody that Cole wrote, but yeah I think I would probably say that I — in my own writing and I think Cole does the same thing — we really like to have some level of accessibility to it so that it feels like, you know, what you just described, and I really appreciate that, because that's definitely something we're going for. And I kind of learned that from my years of a couple of decades of being in Bob Mintzer's band and I've always been a huge Bob fan and I'm so thrilled I got to work for him for so long before he moved to Los Angeles. But to me his music really had that kind of quality. There was always something that I would take away in kind of a memorable way like you just described. So I suppose part of that comes from emulating Bob a little bit.

MR: I wrote down a note here saying it must be a luxury to write for players like that who are going to play it so wonderfully. And then I realized that it's a luxury that you may have to pay for yourself.

MD: That's a hundred percent accurate. Yes. Yeah, it's not — to make a big band record you're really not looking to recoup even a modest amount of your investment in the product itself. Yes. You're absolutely right. It's absolutely fantastic to work with musicians of the caliber on "Open City" is and you know there's so many really stand out excellent players in New York so we always talk about the depth of players here. So you get down to your eighth call trombone player, it's still going to be really good. As opposed to some cities that could have — all cities have really good players no doubt, but it's the depth that you don't really have so much of. So that's a real plus here in New York being able to just — and I was able to get pretty much — all my first call people were available. And I booked it for the beginning of January which is typically like a little bit slower timeframe. So if I were trying to book it like for right now, the spring or summer, it would be hit and miss in terms of the players. But yes, it's a very expensive proposition to do it. And I try to make sure everybody gets paid. I would love to be able to pay them more but I think I've built a reputation of being fair and trying to be as

generous as I can. But you're a hundred percent right, you are going to pay for that if you decide to do that project.

MR: So among your projects, you've had "Trumpets 11," you've had a project with seemingly every trombone player in New York in "Brass Nation," 55 of the world's finest brass players. So don't you think you ought to try some big project now? I had a situation — some years ago I did my own record and I had Bill Watrous and Jerome Richardson on it. I had this weird feeling, like on a couple of occasions they weren't exactly playing what I had written sort of exactly like I wanted it. But I had a hard time telling those guys like anything. Have you had that circumstance with all these — you've bad Bobby Shew and Chuck Findley and —

MD: Oh without question. And I think, you know, undoubtedly you approached it in a similar way. Like I just try to be — I try to express what I'm thinking and what I want to be different but I do it in a very respectful and nice, hopefully nice way. But I'm certainly, and I was fortunate to work with Bill Watrous myself quite a bit and, you know, especially people of my generation, Bill was a big time hero and you know, you just kind of naturally react to that. But there were a couple of times with Bill like when we were recording the "Absolute Trombone" record where he kind of didn't want to do it the way I wanted him to do it. I kind of just was like all right, you're Bill Watrous, you do it the way you want. But for the most part it rarely ends up being that.

MR: Is there — with technology these days — is there a feeling sometimes that you're giving it away for free?

MD: For sure, yeah. It is very challenging and if I were doing a project like "Open City" like I said for the money or in the hopes of recouping the investment in it, it would be foolhardy. There is, you know the old time go down to Tower Records and spend $8 or $10 on a record and that's it and you know, people can make bootleg cassettes or whatever. But now I mean pretty much as soon as the record comes out it's on YouTube for free. So you know I think there are people who — I'm certainly one of them — that when I — I want to buy the music because I want to support the artist that I'm getting so much joy and enjoyment out of listening to. So to me I think there are a lot of people like that but then I think there are a lot of people that — especially in the younger generation, in fairness to them, you know they're used to getting everything for free in terms of their music, or at a very low cost. So these streaming services like Apple or Spotify, whatever, the amount, it's fractions of a penny every time it gets played. So there's little hope of making much other than pocket change back from that side of things. You know I have my own company, Hip-Bone Music and so we'll sell the arrangements through that so that's a possible revenue stream in terms of recouping. It still won't get anywhere near

calling card. Or business card. It's saying here's my new stuff that I've been working on and hopefully the byproduct is some gigs you weren't expecting maybe or appearances at a college or a high school that wants to hire you as a guest, those type of things. And I do think that that is a lane that you can get in and have some success with that. But again you're still — you have to make an initial investment that probably won't be recouped.

MR: Musicians are going to do it anyway, aren't they?

MD: Absolutely. Absolutely. Yeah I mean it's actually quite amazing to me how many big bands are going right now in New York over the last couple years. Big band leaders, younger players all the way up to folks my age and ten, fifteen years older than me. Yeah. I mean they keep coming, they keep doing it, and it's great. It's great. Because that's what it is — it is about the music and it is about serving the music and getting it out there. So I think it's great that people are passionate about their music and their projects and it's important. But you're right, the musicians are going to keep doing that regardless of the shortfall in terms of the economics.

MR: I watched a video of you playing "Waiting on a Friend" at the Burghausen Fest, and I will have to say that's an impressive display of sackbut ability.

MD: Well you're very kind Monk, thank you. Yeah some days I feel like I can get around the thing and other days I'm trying to figure it out still.

MR: Well that leads me to — what are you — let's put it this way, if you met somebody who is not a musician, like my father used to be so confused by what are they doing. He'd hear somebody that was clearly improvising and I couldn't — at the time I can't remember what I said to him. But can you succinctly explain to someone just a kernel of what improvising is?

MD: I probably won't be very succinct but I'll try anyway. Yeah I think of it as you know the thing I would draw the closest parallel to might be if you listen to a Mozart symphony you're going to hear melody, you're going to hear harmony, and then you're going to hear counterpoint, which is material that is supplementing and complementing the melody and the harmony. And that's all written down in an orchestral composition. But to me, you know we talked about Charlie Parker earlier. Charlie Parker, his improvisation is basically the same as Mozart counterpoint except that he's doing it on the fly. He's not writing it down, he's not — he hasn't necessarily prepared it although I think jazz musicians develop a vocabulary that they're comfortable using. That's why any of us can hear Charlie Parker and know right away it's Charlie Parker. Or you can hear right away that it's Mike Rodriguez or pick whoever you like. So to me I guess I've already crossed the line of being succinct but to me it's really, it's counterpoint. It's that element of the music that you're used to hearing in a symphony or in anything — in rock & roll too.

four elements and the one element in jazz that is counterpoint is an improvised solo that's happening in real time. You're not writing down anything, you're not playing exactly what you prepared, you're reacting to the other players and the other input you're getting from the other players as opposed to a written symphony. But conceptually it's kind of the same kind of material.

MR: That particular song I mentioned, that Stones song, has a fairly basic chord progression. Do you feel that you're more likely to play outside the changes on a song like that, that has less harmonic material than I guess — more than what — well maybe like a standard bebop with more changes.

MD: I think the answer to that would be yes for me. I mean I think it's easier — easier is not the right word — I think it lends itself to more harmonic experimentation if the bass of the chords, the harmonic movement of the chords, is simpler. It gives you I think a little bit more time to develop things in terms of playing outside the key centers. But that said of course you can listen to, you know pick whoever you want but you know you listen to John Coltrane play, he's using all kinds of substitutions on standards and chords, tritone substitutions, all kinds of different — and superimposing different chords over the top of another chord. So I think it's still very — it lends itself very much so to reharmonizing, even when there's more harmonic movement and more kind of — what's the right word — complex chord changes. Let's say that.

MR: Is there such a thing as wrong notes for you?

MD: Yeah.

MR: Me too.

MD: Yeah I mean you know certainly playing — I mean for a brass player it's kind of interesting. This was my first job when I got out of college was with Buddy Rich, which I'm still to this day grateful for that opportunity. It was awesome. He, you know he was a lunatic in his own kind of way but a genius in another way. And I was so thrilled to get the call on that. I actually left Eastman three months before graduation, much to the chagrin of my mom and everybody else that, "You're making a mistake." I knew I wasn't, and I didn't. It was a good move and I got to play with Buddy for two years and got tremendous growth out of it, it's probably that. But Buddy would always scream and yell whenever brass players would crack a note. So when we crack a note it's just when somehow our embouchure doesn't respond in the way we want it to. To me that's different from a wrong note. A wrong note is playing, "Oh I was supposed to play a B natural there but I played a B flat instead." Okay that's a wrong note to me. But that's a brass player thing. So we kind of have to deal with trumpet and trombone and tuba and French horn — we have to kind of deal with that aspect of instrumental playing that

player. But certainly in terms of improvisation if I play a note that's — I'm not intending, and I can't figure out my way to get out of it, then that's kind of a wrong note. But that's not to say that you can play unintended notes that don't lead you down another path that really opens up something else that you weren't even thinking of when that note occurred.

MR: I have a little quote here from Bill Dobbins, who I know you know who Bill Dobbins is.

MD: Absolutely.

MR: He said, "An essential part of real musicianship as an improviser or composer is the ability to use any note on the chromatic scale on any chord and make it sound believable."

MD: I think that's a great quote, I mean and Bill can do that himself. I mean he's an incredible musician and educator as well. Yeah I totally agree with that, and certain people are so fluid at it. I was listening to a Michael Brecker record a few days ago and I'm like what is he playing on that. And it's like he's playing a major third on a minor chord and it sounds like a million bucks. And I don't know exactly why that's working like that — but I mean I kind of know why it is but certain players just have that ability to basically what Bill — you quoted Bill as saying, and that's basically playing any note on any chord and making it sound good.

MR: Yeah. Miles Davis — you know something about with his Harmon mute it's almost like he could play anything and somehow it's like, "Yeah that's great."

MD: I totally agree with you. I totally agree with that. And the beauty in his sound also helps a lot to make it — you know I think the Harmon is such a great sound the way he played it. And I think having a sound that you really love listening to makes those notes that maybe are outside of the chord center, makes those easier to listen to.

MR: I can't let this go by — I'm picturing you calling your mother saying, "Mom I'm leaving Eastman to go with Buddy Rich." "Who's Buddy Rich?" Did she know who Buddy Rich was?

MD: She knew who Buddy Rich was, yeah, yeah. But yeah I mean the thing is I went to Eastman because they had a history of placing trombone players on Woody Herman's band, especially like ten years before me, like for instance Jim Pugh and Birch Johnson and all these guys that I really looked up to and still do. And they were — it was kind of a pipeline there for a little bit so I thought well that's the place that I should go. And as it turns out I ended up — I did play with Woody for a little bit but most of my big band time was with Buddy Rich. But it was a good pipeline and I knew when I got the call that this call might not happen again and I can always come back and finish my degree, which I did, and quite honestly a degree in trombone performance — an undergraduate degree

experience — extremely valuable. I mean it's not like a music education degree where you can plug that into a work environment that you can get a job at. So it's about — it's like what we talked about at the beginning, the freelancing thing. It's giving you the tools to be able to be a freelance musician. So I just thought this makes sense to me to take this. I understand it from my mom's perspective. But she ended up being quite supportive about it so it all worked out in the end.

MR: Did the fellas in the Buddy Rich band sort of band together to — I can't finish my sentence.

MD: I know where you're going with this. Yeah. A hundred percent. Yeah it was kind of a us against him kind of vibe. And not always, and you know there's all these tapes of him screaming, yelling at the band, and I was on several of those. But he wasn't like that every day. You know it was, eh, a couple of times a month or something like that if I were to break it down, he'd get just really in a bad mood and take it out on the band a little bit. And during those periods it would definitely be kind of us against him. But other times he could be — he was a super funny guy when he wanted to be and he could kind of wrap his arms around us so to speak and include people on things. But I would say it was certainly a 50/50 situation — it was 50% of the time it was us against him.

MR: And what about, let's see Buddy Rich, Rolling Stones, Frank Sinatra?

MD: Yeah.

MR: Couldn't play with anybody good, ey?

MD: Yeah, I'm grateful for all the opportunities I've had. It's been a terrific run. And if somebody would have told me 42 years ago when I got out of Eastman, "Here's what you're going to do would you take it right now?" I would take it in a heartbeat. And Sinatra was awesome. I mean when I started I was kind of the young guy on the band and the older guys who had been there for a long time, most of which are passed on now, they were really super great to me. They took me under their wing and the stories were incredible. And also that book of music to me is — there'll never be a collection of arrangements that good again. Because not to say there aren't great arrangers because there certainly are, but every one of those, you know when Sinatra picked up the phone so to speak, you know those arrangers brought their A game to the highest degree. So whether you're playing a Billy May chart or a Nelson Riddle chart, which Nelson was probably the most associated with Frank, or Johnny Mandel, or Gordon Jenkins or Don Costa. These — they were all — every chart is a 10. And so for me as a young person getting to play that book, I loved every minute of it. It was awesome and you're just hearing these absolute gems. You can't play it wrong. You know you might crack a note but the figures are so beautifully constructed and the voicings and everything, it's just

— well the arrangements still exist — they're just such absolute gems. And so it's unlikely that there would be a big band that would have that many different arrangers with different styles but all be that great. So it was a very special book of music to get to play on a nightly basis.

MR: Yeah, to sit and be in the middle of that and realize the skill it took to know what not to write as well as what to write.

MD: Yeah. Hundred percent. And you know I mean the one — Nelson Riddle comes to mind — I mean such a great arranger. And you know he was a trombone player, not a particularly great trombone player, but he was a trombone player, typically playing in a big band section, probably playing third trombone. And the way he learned how to write was he would write on little pieces of — you know like a single stave — and just write out some voicings. And he would get done with a rehearsal and just ask the guys to stick around for a couple of minutes and just play a couple of things. That's how he learned how to arrange. You know there were no arranging books then or opportunities for him to try it. So he totally — he was sitting in the band and had obviously great ears and was listening to everything and figuring out okay how should I voice this, and what works good here, and you know all the different techniques that the great arrangers use. But he just figured them out by — very organically. So, and I'm sure many of the other arrangers same thing. But I know that story about Nelson for fact because people talk about it quite often.

MR: You were horn-mates with Tim Ries is that correct?

MD: That's correct, yeah.

MR: Here's a quote, when I spoke to him about the Rolling Stones he said, "You get to know their kids and grandkids and wives, it's like a big traveling family."

MD: Yeah they're great people to work for. I loved how they treated the band — terrific. You know they could very easily have been off to themselves, the four Stones and just dealt with the upper level management, but they treated the band, we all flew on the same private plane with them. We always stayed at the same hotels with them and they treated you like you were a band you know. And obviously Keith and Mick and Charlie and Ron are more important than the saxophone player or the trombone player, but they viewed it like everybody was of value to them and they acted and treated us accordingly. Yeah, extremely grateful in many respects the best job I've ever had. But on the other hand there's other factors involved in it too but they were terrific to work for.

MR: I assume that they gave you a lot of notice when they were going to do a tour so that you could free up your calendar?

MD: Yeah. And typically back then — I haven't been with them for a number of years — but

year. The last one that I did spanned two years for a couple of different reasons. But you knew, they would give you a contract and you would be — it would be typically about a year. But like I said, sometimes longer. But yeah, they give you notice and every aspect of their approach to running the operation was so professional. It was really easy. You've got to just get up and make it to the lobby, and everything else will take care of itself.

MR: Do you remember that quote from Charlie Watts about you?

MD: I do, yeah.

MR: Do you mind saying it for me?

MD: Well yeah, he said, "In this bone dry era it's essential to have Michael Davis around." It's not so applicable anymore 'cause there's so many great trombone players now that, I mean it's never been healthier for the trombone in terms of the players that are playing now from Marshall Gilkes to Michael Dease to Ryan Keberle to just endless number — it feels like it's endless. But back when I was starting and starting to do my own records, not as much. You know there weren't as many trombone players around doing their own solo things so I think that's why he may have said that. It was very kind of him and probably a little too generous. But I appreciated it of course. And he was a prince of a guy. I mean he was just a total gentleman. He was the anti rock star rock star. Because he would get done with a gig, he'd go to his room, maybe order some room service, go to bed, that's it. And he didn't want to be — I think he really didn't like doing interviews, he didn't really want to do — he was very kind of — but absolutely hysterical guy. I mean the driest sense of humor, it was terrific. So fun to hang out with. And as you know I'm sure, massive jazz fan, so he would always bring in — my trumpet colleague and I are very good friends still and we'd always sit next to each other on the plane and Charlie would come in and, "Look what I just bought, this is Elvin Jones' drumset." And it was like he was so happy. Like that made him much happier than whatever amount of money he was making that week being one of the Rolling Stones. So it was great, I mean he was just so much fun to talk to and hang out with, and a very approachable guy.

MR: Okay I'm going to try a little something on you here. I have a list of some of the people that you've recorded for or perhaps done a tour with. And I'm going to start reading it and I want you to stop me if there's something of significance that you'd like to say about it. All right?

MD: Awesome.

MR: Michael Jackson, Bob Dylan, Aerosmith —

MD: Okay I mean I can say something about all of these —

MR: I bet you can. Yeah we've got six hours here so let's get started.

MD: The Aerosmith session, I just recorded one record for them and it was a kind of a larger

three saxophones. And I just remember — oh what's his last name — David Campbell who is the pop singer Beck who was a big star, still is I guess, Beck, who I played with on some other things but Beck, his dad is a really good arranger and he was kind of known as the arranger for the rock bands. He did some stuff for the Stones, he's done lots of different folks. He was the arranger on it and thank goodness because it was party central in the booth. I mean it sounded like a pet shop burning down whenever they would come on and try to ask us to do something. And there was no way you were — like your question was going to get answered if it weren't for David. So that session was very, like it was chaotic but at the same time a lot of fun and memorable for sure.

MR: I have to remember that to use at some point — "a pet shop burning down." How about Paul Simon or Peter Gabriel?

MD: I did a live show with Peter Gabriel, I think it was on David Letterman I believe when it was still The Letterman Show. And I was always a big Peter Gabriel fan. This guy was like the nicest guy I've ever met, and talking to everybody and just like — and we were just there for the, it was kind of a one-off situation. So he could easily have just not addressed us at all, you know he didn't have to and it wouldn't have affected how the band would sound, but just like the nicest guy you could imagine and a very humble guy considering he was such a mega star.

MR: So these fellas like this, they have arrangers who write out the horn parts for the most part. Is that correct?

MD: Yeah. For the most part, yeah. I mean the Stones for instance did not, and we would use whatever, at that time Bobby Keys, who was kind of their most important and main sax guy, he recorded all those original solos on "Brown Sugar" and "Rip This Joint" and all the tenor solos were played by Bobby. And Bobby was, you know the section leader for sure and so we would kind of — would interface with Bobby in how we were going to — what horn lines we were playing. So occasionally they would ask us to come up with some horn arrangement if you want to say it that way. But and there was no music because they don't read or write music. I mean they write music but they don't read music so there as no — and in fact in the M.D., who was Chuck Leavell, who is a keyboard player, he couldn't read music either. So there was no need for charts per se but I mean their catalogue is so vast that we had to keep kind of little cheat sheets just to remember the stuff. And it's remarkable that they can remember all the tunes. And they tap into their catalogue. They change it up from tour to tour, they change the set quite a bit. So I mean they're obligated like any big star to play the big hits, but yeah, so for them we would come up with arrangements but they were mostly just done without writing anything down. Other bands for sure. Paul Simon I think is in-between. I don't think he

about what he wants. People will kind of add their input in kind of an organic creative process.

MR: Yeah that's like going to graduate school when you get in those situations. Like you can learn what you had at Eastman but you've got to add your own ear and intuition.

MD: A hundred percent. And you know there's a personal dynamic too because you want to know how far you can add input. Because some people don't really want much more than what they're saying and you have to try to interpret that and translate it into working for the horns. And then in the case of, like my experience with the Stones with Bobby, you know we wanted to make sure he was comfortable with everything so we had to be — you know we just had to be aware, you know, of who could get bent out of shape if you start imposing too much information or you know it's too — for lack of a better word — too slick or something, if it's something like the Stones or Bob Dylan or something like that. It's not going to work to have complicated horn lines and complex voiced out things. So I mean I wasn't always aware of it. I became more aware of it as time went by but it makes — it really makes me appreciate like the Sinatra thing that we talked about earlier, just walking in and just an absolute gold — a pile of gold there and all you've got to do is sit down and just play your little part of it and it's going to be fun and great.

MR: Let's talk about advice you might give to young musicians today. I believe this is a quote from you from a previous interview and you said, "The inclusion of musicians on everything from CDs to film soundtracks to television commercials and Broadway shows no longer feels like a given but more like a luxury."

MD: Wow. If I said that I agree with myself then. Yeah, it certainly is, and I think especially now with the whole development of AI and everything that's coming, boy there's — the advice I would have with that in mind is become as versatile as you can become so you can deal with a lot of things and for instance by that I mean of course whatever your primary thing is, in my case it's playing the trombone, be as good as you can possibly be in your primary thing but then also add some other tools to your toolbox. Add arranging. Add composition. If you are technically proficient be good at operating Pro Tools. If you can use Finale and understand how to copy things that's actually also valuable. And then on top of all that, just work on your people skills you know people that work are people that other people like to be around. And you know I think, Monk, it's probably the same as a college professor is the same as — you know people like to be around the people that they like. And so if you can make it easy for them to like you, you know don't create a lot of problems. Don't impose your thoughts all the time. Find out when it's appropriate to add a comment here or there. Know what it is to go into a section and be playing third trombone and the lead trombone player has been there for 25 years and has a way of

going to work a lot more for sure. And all those things I mean I think — I always say when I give clinics it's like you're opening a flower shop and there's already five or six flower shops within a couple mile radius of you. So that's not to say that you can't be successful, but what's going to make you more successful? So you know, oh that person always opens at 8:15 but it says 8:00 and, you know I hate going there because their person is always late and I need to get in and out of there so I can go to work or whatever analogy you want to use, all of those things factor in to somebody getting a call and I think now especially. The music business has always been a difficult business and it was challenging when I first started freelancing in New York, but it's harder now and there's less recording work, there's less of the higher end kind of work. There's still some, but it's less and the level of players I would say is generally going up. So basically I'm saying the competition is even greater. Other things I would just add, just from a personal standpoint with my son Cole, who I had mentioned earlier who wrote "Open City," he's really developed his own Patreon channel like focusing on teaching and he does a Transcription Tuesday and he does a Monday Morning Warm-up session. He's a bass player. And he's gotten hundreds and hundreds of subscribers in about a year's time and he's really turned it into — it's financially successful. So he figured out a way to use that tool — Patreon — and turn it into something that works for him and it enables him to use his skills in a way that can be profitable. So anything you could do like that — I'm sure there's stuff that I'm not even aware of or have the ability to do that younger folks would take to quite naturally.

MR: Well said. I want to talk about compositional inspiration for a moment. I was looking at your catalogue and I'm assuming these are your tunes or maybe your son's. There was this song called "A Life Lived" from 9/11 time, and then on the other spectrum there's something called "Stomper" which you described as a Steely Dan meets Jaco meets Dave Matthews.

MD: That's very generous of me to describe that that way.

MR: So what inspires a melodic line for you? Where does it start?

MD: I'm not sure where it starts. I mean I think there's a couple different approaches that I use and one is melody based, you know where the first thing that you come up with is a melody that anybody could — you just have something in your head and it could be a fragment of something else you'd heard that day, it could be — it could come from anywhere. It could be oh I had MLB network on and they had this like goofball theme and like for some reason it stuck in my head and then two weeks later you have something that resembles that or you know, whatever it might be, it just kind of comes out organically. And then you go from there. The other thing you could do is come up

melody in on top of that. And then kind of the third way would be dealing with the rhythmic element first and that's going to create a different approach to how you're going to write the melody. So I think I just kind of roll with whatever happens on that. The two tunes that you are referencing, "Life Lived" is a composition for six trombones that I wrote for a record I did called "New Brass." And yeah, it's exactly, it was a dedication to victims of 9/11. So you know that kind of has an implication about what kind of music that's going to be. It's kind of somber and in memoriam of that horrible day. "Stomper" is — I wanted to do something on a record I did called "Absolute Trombone II" that was for six trombones and drums. No bass or piano. And "Stomper," I kept all my Bay Area teams so I'm a big Oakland A's fan which is really really hard to do right now. But "Stomper" is the mascot of the A's. So my youngest son Zack, who is a trumpet player, he became a big A's fan. I think he just liked the colors, I'm not really sure why, when he was two years old he just — so we would always go to an A's game when they're in New York and sometimes in other cities as well and we would see this character "Stomper" which is an elephant which is back from the Connie Mack era when they were the Philadelphia Athletics. So that gives you a different kind of, you know, conjures up something else, like the music from "Life Lived" wouldn't work well with the title "Stomper."

MR: Yes, you answered my question about titles.

MD: Bob Mintzer told me once, I took some lessons from him before I was in his band, for composition and arranging. And Bob said, "You know before you start it title your song." And it was really an interesting thought. I don't always do it, sometimes I do it after it's done and has a vibe that I think works. But I thought that was a cool thing to say because then that gives you a direction at least that you're going to go musically, what's the style of this you know. So that's another thing that can be done.

MR: If you're in the midst of arranging a piece do you carry it around with you in your head even when you're not working on it?

MD: Yeah a hundred percent, yeah. And sometimes to the point of I want it to leave my head and I can't get it out of my head. And then of course there's the — you're committed to it and you've done it all and it's still in your head and you realize oh I wish I had done something different. That's often part of the equation. So I find it to be a pretty frustrating process to be honest with you Monk, composition in general. And you hear these great songwriters talk about it from Billy Joel to Sting to Carla Bley, you know all range of styles. And a lot of them say the same thing you know and you're writing and writing and then it's just terrible so you throw it away and you start again and you just wasted the whole day. But that's part of the process I think and all these great composers always

I think when you're writing 'cause it's not just going to flow out of you even if you're really good at it. It's trial and error. Some things are going to work, some things aren't and you're going to want to change stuff. So you've got to give yourself some patience.

MR: Have you written a chart that has no improvised sections in it? No solo sax, nothing?

MD: Yeah quite a few actually, but almost all of them are for brass that I've done for that. I did a brass quintet record in 2019 and there's no improvising on that record at all. It's just a standard brass quintet: two trumpets, French horn, trombone and tuba. And all the players could improvise and had the versatility to play whatever stylistically was put in front of them. And you know it's classically oriented but it has that accessibility factor that I'm always trying to go for. But it's certainly not jazz even in an improvised way or harmonically. There are jazz elements but there's no improvisation.

MR: The few times I've tried that, I'll work and work and work and then I'll play it back and I go I like it except it's only like 70 seconds long. It's time for a solo.

MD: Yeah. There's something nice about being able to rely on improvisation to beef up a chart a little bit.

MR: What's on your plate at the moment that you're working on?

MD: I'm actually working on a new series of — what do I want to call them — it's twelve standards, two choruses on each standard, and my son and I, Cole and I, are producing it together. We're getting some of our favorite brass players so we're starting with Mike Rodriguez and Marshall Gilkes. They — we send them the rhythm tracks which Cole sort of organized, and then we're transcribing all their solos and putting it out as a transcription book, also you'll get the play-along tracks that you can play yourself along with an analysis of what they're actually — how they're approaching various chords and whatnot. And it's all standards. It's everything from "All The Things You Are" to "Giant Steps" to "Bolivia" to "Stella By Starlight," you know things like that and "Impressions." So that's a really time consuming project. I didn't think it was going to be this time consuming. I'm trying to get Mike's — we're starting with Mike Rodriguez's book and I'm down to my — in fact as soon as we finish today I'm going to have to finish up the last solo but I'm close to finishing it. But I wish he wasn't quite as good as he is but that's just what it is.

MR: "Come on, Mike, that's not transcribable."

MD: "It's too hard to transcribe you, man."

MR: And sometimes I've read reviews and, in *DownBeat*, dissecting solos and trying to make sense of what someone's doing over a certain chord symbol and the lengths that you may have to go to to say okay they're playing the sharp nine here and they played it two bars before that. And I guess what I'm trying to say, sometimes it's hard to explain why

MD: Yeah, totally. And I think the most valuable thing is not — I mean it's valuable to have an analysis of it for sure. But to me the most valuable thing is seeing — I mean I've worn out my Freddie Hubbard book that I think Hal Leonard might be the publisher of it. I mean those became like the same as the classical etudes that I would practice every day and like we called it they're "Rochut Etudes" — these vocal etudes that are very, very standard in the trombone pedagogue world. But the Freddie Hubbard solos to me are just as important and just as applicable. So you know really trying to mirror his phrasing, that's the real import of this project I think. But having an analysis makes it — pardon me — having the analysis certainly makes it — if you want to dive into that it gives you that option to do that.

MR: Do you feel driven to help in any way you can to keep the trombone alive?

MD: For sure. That's why this was years — actually this is our 30 anniversary of Hip-Bone Music when I started. And the first record that I did was with the 16 different trombone players from New York, although Watrous was in town so we got him to play on two of the tracks. He was the only guy that wasn't a New York-based person. But people like Steve Turré, Robin Eubanks, Conrad Herwig, Birch Johnson, Jim Pugh played on that, Dave Taylor. And a lot of that was, yeah, for what you're just describing Monk, like trying to highlight the instrument for what it can do. And I certainly still subscribe to that a hundred percent. It's a lot easier now because of all these phenomenal younger players like Marshall and Mike Dease and Ryan Keberle who are just taking the instrument and running with it, so it's in really good hands. So I think the work that those gentlemen — and many others too — I'm leaving people out that I shouldn't be leaving out. But it's very healthy right now so I feel — I think the trombone is in good shape for decades to come.

MR: I'm happy to hear you say that because some people take the other attitude that the music business is in the pits and so forth, and I'm glad to hear you optimistic about it.

MD: It is — those people are right. It's not a tremendously healthy business but those people that want to get into it and are committed to doing the work, you can do it. You know, you can. And is it the same, you know, my generation you had to be a good player but it was really about answering the phone. You know it was about, hey, once I develop a good reputation there was enough work and loyalty and everything else that went along with it, all I had to do was answer the phone, say yes, and go to the jobs. It wasn't quite that simple but once I got established that's kind of what it was. Now you have to create your own lane. And that's a much wider challenge. But when you do, and if you do, you control that lane which is great. I'd much rather be in control of my own destiny, especially if I'm able to survive as a professional musician, than rely on a contractor X, Y

‘cause they will, that they’d rather use and somebody else over here. So that’s the advantage right now is if you can create your own lane and have success with it I think the longevity is going to be there.

MR: Well you just gave some great advice.

MD: Well thank you. I guess I’m old enough now that hopefully something comes out that makes sense.

MR: Yeah. I was struck the other day I was reading some stuff on the Musicians’ Union and there was a historical footnote that in 1927 when the “soundies” started, when they figured out how to put sound on film, that thousands of pit musicians became unemployed. So some things never change.

MD: That’s right, yeah. But you know there’s still a lot of work on Broadway for live musicians. So I know the sky was falling but that’s almost a hundred years ago now and it’s still going. And is it as healthy as it’s been? No. But it’s still a viable piece of the business, especially in New York in terms of freelancing as an instrumentalist. So you know I get why people especially of my generation and older are not thrilled about things because there’s a lot not to be thrilled about. But there’s also opportunities for young players and it’s not all gloom and doom. I remember somebody said to me one time, every generation says that. You know you get to New York and the older generation says, “Oh man, you should have been here back when,” you know and “you should have been here back then” and the older generation told them that. You know when was this period that everybody keeps referring to? You know it’s always like that so I mean you know I think you’ve got to be — I think you’ve got to be fired up and passionate and your work ethic has to be totally on point, but I believe it’s still very much a possibility to have success in the business.

MR: Well on that upbeat note, I want to thank you for your time. This was really informative and entertaining as well.

MD: Oh Monk, thank you so much. Like I said, I’ve been a fan of the series and your work and when you sent me the email inviting me to do this I was super, super honored and happy to have the opportunity.

MR: All right. Best of luck with that tough transcription you’re working on.

MD: Thanks. I have a feeling I’m going to be up late tonight.

MR: All right. Over and out.

MD: Thank you Monk.